finance and international operational areas' and assigning such committees the 'responsibility for results'.

The study undertaken by Ratan and the Strategic Plan he recommended the chairman must initiate, along with the questions that the plan should address, made him an ideational leader. It set him apart from the rest of the heads of Tata Group companies.

A Meeting of Minds

JRD convened a meeting on 20 March 1978 to consider the note that was sent to him. He agreed with all the important suggestions. The minutes of the meeting, issued on 4 May 1978, recorded that he concurred with holding periodic meetings with the heads of all Tata Sons' divisions and meetings of the Directors' Coordination Committee (DCC) on 'the first Wednesday of every month'. In addition, he agreed to hold 'regular meetings of Tata Sons/Industries to discuss policies affecting companies and their important divisions' and making 'more frequent visits to the companies, plants and factories outside Bombay'.

The most important of all the decisions that JRD took was the preparation of the 'Tata Plan'. It paved the way for the famous 1983 Strategic Plan that Ratan later authored.

But there was opposition from the senior members of the group as they were 'concerned about their autonomy'. Their narrow approach of dealing with companies denied the apex bodies (TIL and Tata Sons) the advantages of a synergic and cohesive approach. All this would, however, slowly change after the plan. But the big bang reforms had to wait for his elevation as chairman of Tata Sons. For the time being, with his note, Ratan earned JRD's admiration for being a visionary. It was to have significant implications for him in the future.

To Go or Not to Go

The year 1979 was significant for Ratan. The forty-two-year-old had still not found an important position in the Tata Group. Suddenly, some 14,000 kilometres away in Los Angeles, a new opportunity opened for him.

In August 1979, Quincy Jones, the man who had given Ratan his first job, died. Soon after, Quincy's widow, Elaine Sewell, made Ratan an offer